There is no doubt that the Prime Minister touched a deep chord in the heart of India when he talked of the menace of corruption. Who among us has not felt 'Some people have misused their office for personal gain… that corruption and black money tend to be accepted as part of life… that it has afflicted our politics, our administration and our society like an infestation of termites…'

According to the 2017 Transparency International[8] Corruption Perception Index (CPI) report, 73 per cent of the bribes paid in India were by 'the low economy groups, who had to pay money due to unavailability of other options, or had less influence to avoid paying bribes... high bribes were demanded for accessing public education and healthcare facilities… approximately 58 per cent and 59 per cent bribery rates were seen in education and healthcare sectors in India, respectively. The times when people paid a bribe was also seen to be almost equally high for police, identification documents, and basic amenities.'

The Prime Minister's promise that demonetization would eradicate corruption was undoubtedly one of the main reasons for the initial goodwill towards demonetization from the very poor, despite the hardships it inflicted on them. Sadly, however, this promise too was belied.

In February 2018, Transparency International reported that India continued to be among the most corrupt countries in the world. In the 2017 Global Corruption Perception Index report, India, with a score of 40 points, was ranked 81, down two places from its ranking of 79 in 2016.

More worryingly, India was named among the 'worst offenders' in terms of graft and press freedom in the Asia Pacific region. In their report, Transparency International said, 'In some countries across the region (Asia Pacific), journalists, activists, opposition leaders and even staff of law enforcement or watchdog agencies are threatened, and in the worst cases, even murdered... Philippines, India, and the Maldives are among the worst regional offenders in this respect. These countries